THE NEXT HAND

How the Best Innovate

Notes and toolkit · Creativity & Design Thinking
SFIMAR, St. Francis Institute of Management and Research, Borivali · 17 Oct 2026

Nishit Kamath

Founder, The Next Hand · Co-founder, VNV Printlab

Scan for all my links
live.thenexthand.com/links

Find me

Website	thenexthand.com
LinkedIn	linkedin.com/in/nishitkamath
Instagram	@nishkamath
X	@nishitkamath

Inside

1. Summary: six companies, four suits (p. 2)
2. Toolkit, AI, Experiment Card, road to 27 Nov (p. 3)
3. Appendix A · How to use each tool (p. 4)
4. Appendix B · The six companies in full (p. 8)
5. Appendix C · Short forms (p. 14)
6. Appendix D · Sources (p. 14)
7. Disclaimer and credits (p. 15)

For learning only. Facts were checked against the sources in Appendix D, but may still contain errors. Not professional advice. Company names belong to their owners; no company has reviewed or endorsed these notes. Full disclaimer on the last page. © 2026 Nishit Kamath · The Next Hand. All rights reserved.

THE NEXT HAND · NOTES

How the Best Innovate

Creativity & Design Thinking · SFIMAR, St. Francis, Borivali · 17 Oct 2026 · Nishit Kamath

NOTES + TOOLKIT
FOR INNOHATCH, TO 27 NOV

You can't choose your hand. Only your next move. Innovation isn't luck or genius: it's a process you can copy, and test this week.

Six companies, four suits

THE SAME FOUR QUESTIONS FOR EACH · FULL PAGES IN APPENDIX B

COMPANY	♠ Where ideas start	♥ How they understand people	♦ How they test	♣ How they scale	✋ Steal this, this week
IDEO	Rules make wild ideas safe.	Start with what people want, then ask: can we build it, will it pay?	Rough, fast and cheap teaches you sooner.	Give your method away.	**30 ideas in 20 minutes, using the 7 brainstorm rules.**
Apple	Saying no creates focus.	People can't ask for what they've never seen, so Apple shows them first.	Customers feel quality they can't name.	In big teams, nobody owns the problem.	**One owner (DRI) per task, plus a "not doing" list.**
Samsung	Sometimes the problem is the whole culture.	You can't design for people you never meet.	Learn from a rival by taking its product apart.	Keep your entrepreneurs instead of losing them.	**Take a rival product apart as a mixed team; list 10 insights.**
3M	Free time breeds ideas.	Mistakes are the price of initiative.	A great product can still flop if people don't get it.	Culture fades unless you feed it.	**90 minutes a week on your own experiment; show it in 3 minutes.**
Google	Give people time and products follow (20% time: News, AdSense).	Five days beats five months of debate.	Do the hardest part first.	The best teams are safe teams.	**A one-day sprint, tested with 5 real people.**
VNV Printlab	Today's friction is tomorrow's market.	The people affected know what you don't.	Ask the experts the right questions early.	A small studio can remember like a big company.	**Show a sketch or model to 3 customers before you build.**

Myth checks

THE POPULAR STORY VS THE RECORD

✕ **IDEO:** "IDEO designed Apple's mouse." Its forerunner Hovey-Kelley Design did (1980–81); IDEO formed in 1991.

✕ **Samsung:** "The turnaround was only about quality." Design was central too: SADI (1995), the Design Revolution (1996).

✕ **Google:** "Gmail came from 20% time." It was an assigned project; News and AdSense were 20% projects.

✕ **Apple:** "Apple does no market research." Court filings (2012) showed regular buyer surveys.

✕ **3M:** "Post-it was a lucky accident." Glue (1968) + bookmark idea (1974) + years of championing.

Why check? Famous stories make innovation look like luck. The record shows a process. Checking a "fact" is the habit you need with AI too.

Where the four suits come from

Like a hand of cards (in rummy you're dealt 13 and can only change what you pick up and throw away), every company plays the same four suits. The suits lens, the 6C process and the S·C·O·R·E Experiment Card are NISHIT KAMATH'S METHOD The rest is credited where it's used, with sources at the back.

The toolkit: one process, four tools HOW-TO FOR EACH IN APPENDIX A

6C
MY DESIGN PROCESS

Face a concern → find a cause → compare research → conceive → convince it can exist → continue. At every step: **communicate with the people affected.**

NISHIT KAMATH'S METHOD ArtCenter, 2013

AEIOU
OBSERVE

Activity · **E**nvironment · **I**nteraction · **O**bject · **U**ser. Watch all five before you decide what the problem is.

Doblin Group, Chicago, c. 1994

Task analysis
BREAK IT DOWN

List every step of something ordinary (like making ginger tea). Each step is a place it can go wrong, and a place for a better product.

after Annett & Duncan, 1967

5 E's
MAP THE JOURNEY

Entice → Enter → Engage → Exit → Extend. Where do your customers drop off? Put your next experiment there.

Ben Jacobson, Conifer Research

L.I.F.E
TEST FOR DIGNITY

Does your idea respect what your customer values: their **Love, Identity, Freedom and Expression**?

Nishit Kamath, "Mobility Dignified", 2025

Ask your team
TONIGHT

At which E does our customer drop off? Which step of their task is slowest or messiest? Does our idea respect their dignity?

Using AI well A TEAMMATE, NOT A SEARCH ENGINE

1. **Give it your situation** · Who you are, who the customer is, budget, deadline.
2. **Make it ask first** · "Ask me 5 questions, one at a time, before you answer."
3. **Make it argue** · "Play a sceptical customer. Push back on my price."
4. **Make it build the test** · "Write a 6-question survey and a poster for this."
5. **Check it with a person** · AI can be confidently wrong. Every claim gets one real-world check.

S·C·O·R·E Experiment Card

NISHIT KAMATH'S METHOD

steps follow the Stanford d.school design-thinking modes

S **Scenario** · Who is your customer, where and when? One thing you saw them do.

C **Challenge** · [Customer] needs [need] because [insight].

O **Opportunity** · Your idea in one line + the company move you're stealing.

R **Resolution** · The cheapest test you can make in 48 hours.

E **Expansion** · Test with how many people? What counts as success? First-sale target.

Road to 27 Nov SIX WEEKS, ONE PROOF A WEEK

17–23 Oct Run the experiment

24–30 Oct Change one thing

31 Oct–6 Nov First sale

7–20 Nov Sell + log

21–26 Nov Rehearse 5–7 min

27 Nov Present: evidence, not adjectives

Your next move PLAY IT THIS WEEK

1 · Steal one practice
From IDEO, Apple, Samsung, 3M, Google or VNV (page 1).

2 · Run one experiment
Your Experiment Card, before next Saturday.

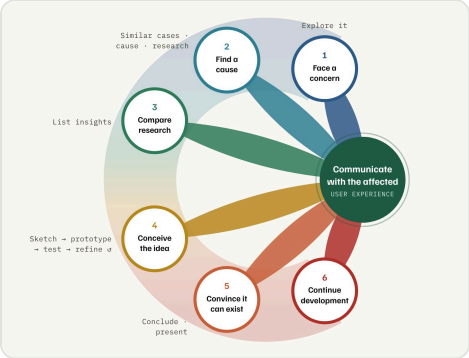
3 · Make one sale
Before 6 Nov, so you have proof on 27 Nov.

Log your proof weekly
live.thenexthand.com/sfimar

MY NOTES · THE ONE THING I'LL TRY THIS WEEK

APPENDIX A · HOW TO USE EACH TOOL

Each tool: when to use it, how, and one way to try it on your InnoHatch idea this week.



6C design process NISHIT KAMATH'S METHOD

ArtCenter College of Design thesis prep, Oct 2013

USE IT WHEN

From the first worry about a problem all the way to launch. It keeps the people affected in every decision.

HOW

1. **Face a concern:** write it in one line. Whose concern is it?
2. **Find a cause:** ask "why?" until you reach something you can change.
3. **Compare research:** how have others solved it (companies, rivals, other fields)? List insights.
4. **Conceive the idea:** sketch at least 3, pick one; sketch → prototype → test → refine.
5. **Convince it can exist:** the cheapest proof: a mock-up, model or sample.
6. **Continue development:** keep testing and improving.
7. **At the centre, every step:** show it to the people affected and listen.

TRY IT ON YOUR IDEA

Which C is your team on today? Write the next one on top of your Experiment Card.

AEIOU Doblin Group, Chicago, c. 1994 (Rick E. Robinson and colleagues) [28]

A	E	I	O	U
Activity	**Environment**	**Interaction**	**Object**	**User**
what the user performs	the setting they perform this in	the connections they create within (area / objects / processes / people)	tools and/or devices that facilitate specific actions and interactions	the people who initiated the activity, their roles, characteristics, goals etc.

USE IT WHEN

Before you decide what the problem is. Go where your customer actually is.

HOW

1. Go to the place (canteen, hostel, bus stop, shop) for 20–30 minutes.
2. Split a page into five columns: A, E, I, O, U.
3. Write what you **see**, not what you think. Photograph with permission.
4. Circle anything that surprises you: that's an insight.
5. Turn the best insight into the S and C of your Experiment Card.

TRY IT ON YOUR IDEA

Observe one real customer of your idea for 20 minutes before Monday.

Task analysis

hierarchical task analysis, after Annett & Duncan, 1967 · ginger-tea example: Nishit Kamath, 2008 [30]



USE IT WHEN

To improve something people already do every day. Every step is a chance to make it easier, safer or nicer.

HOW

1. Name the goal (e.g. "make ginger tea").
2. Break it into 4–6 stages, then each stage into steps.
3. Watch a real person do it; time each step.
4. Mark the pain: waiting, mess, danger, confusion, waste.
5. Each mark is a product or service opportunity. Pick one.

TRY IT ON YOUR IDEA

Break your customer's task (the one your product helps with) into steps. Where do they struggle?

5 E's

Ben Jacobson, Conifer Research [29]



USE IT WHEN

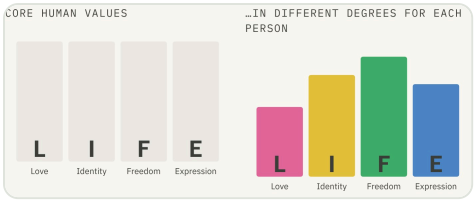
To see your customer's whole experience, from first noticing you to coming back.

HOW

1. **Entice:** what catches their attention?
2. **Enter:** how do they begin?
3. **Engage:** how do they use it?
4. **Exit:** how does it end?
5. **Extend:** why would they remember, recommend or return?
6. Mark where people drop off or get stuck.

TRY IT ON YOUR IDEA

At which E does your customer drop off? Put your next experiment exactly there.



L.I.F.E: design for dignity

Nishit Kamath, "Mobility Dignified", DesignIndia Show, Aug 2025

USE IT WHEN

Before you finalise an idea, and whenever your customer is someone with less power or choice.

HOW

1. Everyone holds four core values: Love, Identity, Freedom, Expression, in different degrees.
2. For your customer, ask of each: does our idea respect it, or chip away at it?
3. Watch for careless design, poor hygiene and poor upkeep: they signal disrespect.
4. Change the idea until it respects all four.

TRY IT ON YOUR IDEA

Ask one customer which of the four matters most to them. Design for that one first.

S·C·O·R·E Experiment Card

NISHIT KAMATH'S METHOD

steps follow the Stanford d.school modes: Empathise, Define, Ideate, Prototype, Test [31]

Scenario · who and where EMPATHISE	Who is your customer, where and when? One thing you saw them do.
Challenge · the problem DEFINE	*[customer]* needs *[need]* because *[insight]*. Insight = the reason behind it you didn't expect.
Opportunity · our idea IDEATE	Your idea in one line, plus the company move you're stealing.
Resolution · the cheapest test PROTOTYPE	What can you make in 48 hours? Paper, a video, a sample, a stall.
Expansion · how we'll know, and what's next TEST	Test with how many people? What counts as success? Your first-sale target before 27 Nov.

USE IT WHEN

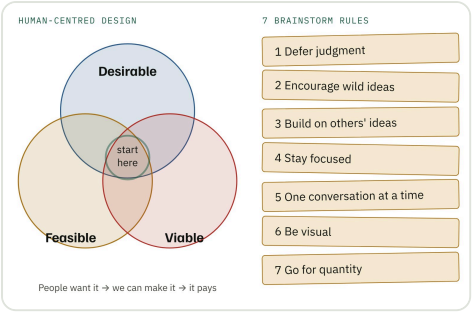
Every week until 27 Nov: one cheap test, written down before you run it.

HOW

1. Fill all five boxes as a team in 10 minutes.
2. Keep the test cheap: something you can make in 48 hours.
3. Decide in advance: how many people, and what counts as success.
4. Run it before next Saturday; photograph it.
5. Log what you tested, learnt and sold at live.thenexthand.com/sfimar.

TRY IT ON YOUR IDEA

Your team's card from today is in the phone app ("Take it with you"). Run it this week.



Human-centred design + IDEO's 7 brainstorm rules

IDEO; rules from IDEO U [2, 3]

USE IT WHEN

When you need many ideas fast, and want to start from people, not technology.

HOW

1. Start where **desirable** (people want it) meets **feasible** (we can make it) and **viable** (it pays).
2. Write one "How might we...?" question.
3. Pin up the 7 rules; one person writes every idea down.
4. Aim for 30 ideas in 20 minutes; no "but" until the end.
5. Vote, then sketch the top 3.

TRY IT ON YOUR IDEA

Run one 20-minute brainstorm on your weakest box of the Experiment Card.

AI as a teammate

Nishit Kamath, for this session

USE IT WHEN

You're stuck, need a first draft, or want someone to argue with. Never as the final answer.

HOW: A PROMPT YOU CAN COPY

```
We're [who], building [idea] for [customer]. Budget ₹[x], [y] weeks. Before you suggest anything, ask us 5 questions, one at a time. Then list our 3 riskiest assumptions and a 48-hour test for each.
```

THEN

Make it argue ("play a sceptical customer"), make it build the test (survey, poster), and check every claim with one real person.

Steal a practice

from page 1

USE IT WHEN

Your team is busy but not learning. One borrowed habit changes how you work.

HOW

1. Pick one row from page 1 that fits your problem.
2. Do it once this week, exactly as written.
3. Note what changed; keep it or drop it.

EXAMPLE

Apple's DRI: put one name next to every task on your list today.

IDEO

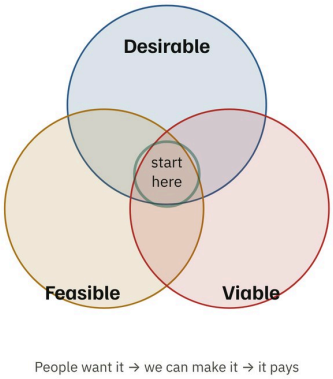
FORMED 1991 · DESIGN CONSULTANCY

Design around people. Prototype early, and rough.

TRUE STORY · 1999

US TV show Nightline (ABC) filmed "The Deep Dive": a mixed team redesigned the supermarket shopping cart in five days. [1, 2, 3, 4]

HUMAN-CENTRED DESIGN



People want it → we can make it → it pays

7 BRAINSTORM RULES

1. Defer judgment
2. Encourage wild ideas
3. Build on others' ideas
4. Stay focused
5. One conversation at a time
6. Be visual
7. Go for quantity

The four suits HOW THEY PLAY EACH SUIT · WHAT WE LEARN FROM IT

	THE MOVE	HOW THEY DO IT	WHAT WE LEARN
♠	**7 brainstorm rules** Where ideas start	Brainstorms run on 7 rules: defer judgment, encourage wild ideas, build on others' ideas, stay focused, one conversation at a time, be visual, go for quantity.	INSIGHT Rules make wild ideas safe. IDEO brainstorms run on 7 rules: defer judgment, build on others' ideas, go for quantity... So no idea gets shot down before it's heard.
♥	**Desirable · feasible · viable** How they understand people	Human-centred design: start with what people desire, then check it's technically feasible and commercially viable.	INSIGHT Start with what people actually want, then ask "can we build it?" and "will it pay?" Most teams go the other way: technology first, people last.
♦	**Rough prototypes, early** How they test	Rough prototypes, fast. Its forerunner's first Apple mouse (1980) was built from a deodorant-bottle ball and a butter dish.	INSIGHT Rough, fast and cheap teaches you sooner. The first Apple mouse was mocked up from a deodorant-bottle ball and a butter dish (1980).
♣	**Teach the method** How they scale	Spreads the method, not only the products: Tim Brown's Change by Design (2009), IDEO.org (2011), free field guides.	OPPORTUNITY Give your method away. IDEO's books, free field guides and IDEO.org teach anyone to work like IDEO, and every reader becomes a fan.

✋ **STEAL THIS, THIS WEEK**

Pin up the 7 rules. Write one "How might we...?" and get 30 ideas in 20 minutes.

× **MYTH CHECK**

"IDEO designed Apple's mouse." Its forerunner, Hovey-Kelley Design, did, in 1980–81. IDEO was formed in 1991.

Sources for this page: [1] Stanford Magazine: Mighty Mouse · [2] IDEO U: 7 rules of brainstorming · [3] IDEO: design thinking · [4] Wikipedia: IDEO

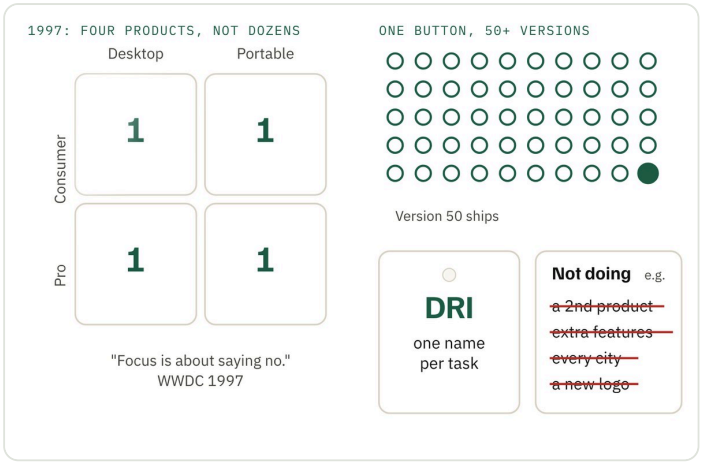
Apple

REFOCUSED 1997 · PRODUCTS

Say no to almost everything, then obsess over what's left.

TRUE STORY · 2001

Tony Fadell joined in April 2001. The iPod launched on 23 Oct 2001. His first mock-ups were foam-core with fishing weights for heft. [5, 6, 7, 8, 9]



The four suits HOW THEY PLAY EACH SUIT · WHAT WE LEARN FROM IT

	THE MOVE	HOW THEY DO IT	WHAT WE LEARN
♠	**Ruthless focus: the 2×2** Where ideas start	Focus. In 1997 Jobs cut the product line to a 2×2 grid: consumer or pro, desktop or portable. "Focus is about saying no." (WWDC 1997)	INSIGHT Saying no creates focus. In 1997 Jobs cut the product line to just four boxes: consumer or pro, desktop or portable. Fewer products, so each one could be great.
♥	**Show, then survey** How they understand people	Shows people what they didn't know to ask for ("people don't know what they want until you show it to them", 1998), and still surveys its buyers.	CHALLENGE People can't ask for what they've never seen, so Apple shows them first. But it still surveys its buyers: gut feel and data, not one or the other.
♦	**50 versions of one button** How they test	A small design team (16 people in 2012) meets around a kitchen table. A single button can go through 50+ versions.	INSIGHT Customers feel quality they can't name. A small design team (16 people in 2012) will take a single button through 50+ versions.
♣	**One DRI per task** How they scale	Experts lead experts in one functional organisation. Every task has a DRI (Directly Responsible Individual): one named owner.	CHALLENGE In big teams, nobody owns the problem. Apple puts one name on every task, the DRI (Directly Responsible Individual), so there's always someone to ask.

✋ **STEAL THIS, THIS WEEK**

Give every task one owner (a DRI, Directly Responsible Individual), and write a "not doing" list.

× **MYTH CHECK**

"Apple does no market research." Court filings in 2012 showed regular surveys of iPhone and iPad buyers.

Sources for this page: [5] HBR: How Apple Is Organized for Innovation (2020) · [6] TechCrunch: "Focus is about saying no" · [7] Macworld: The birth of the iPod · [8] MacTrast: design team testimony (2012) · [9] MRweb: Apple's buyer surveys

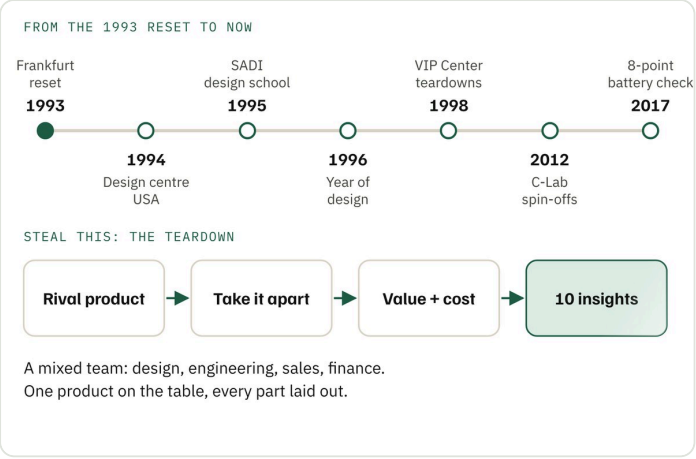
Samsung

REINVENTED 1993 · ELECTRONICS

Change everything. Then make quality and design everyone's job.

TRUE STORY · 1995

At its Gumi factory, about 2,000 staff in "Quality First" headbands watched a reported 150,000 defective phones smashed and burned. [10, 11, 12, 13, 14]



The four suits HOW THEY PLAY EACH SUIT · WHAT WE LEARN FROM IT

	THE MOVE	HOW THEY DO IT	WHAT WE LEARN
♠	**Top-down reset (1993)** Where ideas start	Top-down reinvention. Lee Kun-hee's Frankfurt Declaration (7 Jun 1993): "Change everything except your wife and children." 1996 was declared the Year of Design Revolution.	CHALLENGE Sometimes the problem is the whole culture. In 1993 chairman Lee Kun-hee told his managers in Frankfurt: "Change everything except your wife and children."
♥	**Design centres in markets** How they understand people	Design centres close to customers (USA 1994, Europe 2000, China 2004) and its own design school, SADI (1995).	INSIGHT You can't design for people you never meet. Samsung put design centres in the markets it sells to (USA 1994, Europe 2000, China 2004) and started its own school, SADI (Samsung Art and Design Institute, 1995).
♦	**Teardowns + 8-point checks** How they test	VIP Center (1998): cross-functional teams tear down products and costs together. After the Note7 recall, an 8-point battery safety check (2017).	INSIGHT Learn from a rival by taking its product apart. At the VIP Center (Value Innovation Program, 1998), design, engineering and finance staff dismantle products together to see where value and cost hide.
♣	**C-Lab spin-offs** How they scale	C-Lab (2012): staff incubate ideas inside the company. The best spin off as startups, and staff can return within five years.	OPPORTUNITY Keep your entrepreneurs instead of losing them. C-Lab (Creative Lab, 2012) lets staff build their own ideas inside Samsung. The best spin off as startups, and founders may return within five years.

✋ **STEAL THIS, THIS WEEK**

Run a teardown: take a rival product apart as a mixed team and list 10 insights on value and cost.

× **MYTH CHECK**

"Samsung's turnaround was only about quality." Design was at the centre too: SADI in 1995, the Design Revolution in 1996.

Sources for this page: [10] KED Global: Frankfurt Declaration · [11] Samsung Design: history · [12] Samsung Newsroom: 8-point battery check · [13] Samsung Newsroom: C-Lab · [14] NPR / WWNO: the 1995 phone fire

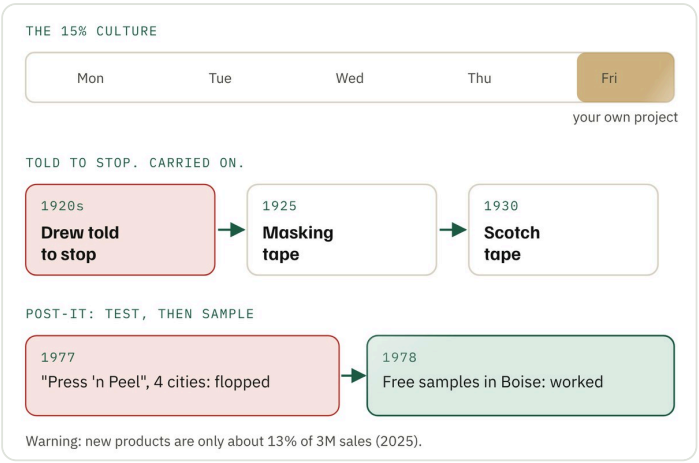
3M

15% CULTURE · MATERIALS

Give people time and tolerance, and let ideas find each other.

TRUE STORY · 1925

McKnight told Richard Drew to stop his tape experiments. Drew carried on, and produced masking tape (1925), then Scotch tape (1930). [15, 16, 17, 18, 19]



The four suits HOW THEY PLAY EACH SUIT · WHAT WE LEARN FROM IT

	THE MOVE	HOW THEY DO IT	WHAT WE LEARN
♠	**15% own-project time** Where ideas start	The 15% culture: staff may spend part of their time on projects they choose. 3M says it has run for more than 70 years.	INSIGHT Free time breeds ideas. 3M staff may spend part of their time, the "15%", on projects they choose. 3M says it has run for over 70 years, and Google copied it.
♥	**Tolerate mistakes** How they understand people	William McKnight's 1948 principles: delegate, let people do the job their own way, tolerate mistakes, don't kill initiative with criticism.	INSIGHT Mistakes are the price of initiative. In 1948 William McKnight told managers: let people do the job their own way, and don't kill initiative with criticism.
♦	**Test markets, then samples** How they test	Post-it was test-marketed first. "Press 'n Peel" in four cities (1977) flopped. Free samples in Boise (1978) worked.	CHALLENGE A great product can still flop if people don't get it. Post-it, sold as "Press 'n Peel", failed in four cities (1977). Free samples in Boise (1978) worked: people had to try it to want it.
♣	**Grants + shared forum** How they scale	Genesis grants fund internal projects, and a Technical Forum shares ideas across divisions. Today's warning: new products are only about 13% of sales (2025).	CHALLENGE Culture fades unless you feed it. Grants and a shared Technical Forum spread ideas across 3M, yet new products are now only about 13% of its sales (2025).

✋ **STEAL THIS, THIS WEEK**

Book 90 minutes a week for a self-chosen experiment, then show it to the class in 3 minutes.

× **MYTH CHECK**

"Post-it was a lucky accident." Silver's glue (1968) waited for Fry's bookmark idea (1974) and years of championing before the 1980 launch.

Sources for this page: [15] 3M: 15% Culture · [16] Smithsonian: the invention of Scotch tape · [17] MNopedia: Post-it Notes · [18] Tuck case: 3M · [19] 3M Q4 2025 earnings call

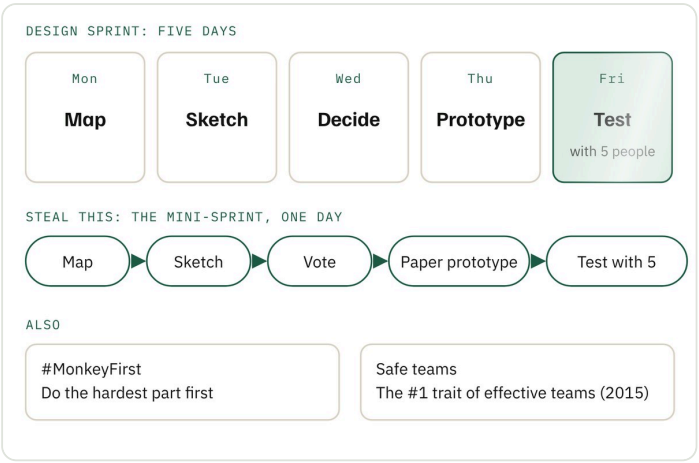
Google

SINCE 1998 · SOFTWARE

Set big goals, test small and fast, and make it safe to speak up.

TRUE STORY · 2001–04

Paul Buchheit started Gmail in August 2001. Googlers used it for about three years before it launched on 1 April 2004. [20, 21, 22, 23, 24]



The four suits HOW THEY PLAY EACH SUIT · WHAT WE LEARN FROM IT

	THE MOVE	HOW THEY DO IT	WHAT WE LEARN
♠	**20% time (now rarer)** Where ideas start	20% time (in the 2004 IPO letter, inspired by 3M) produced Google News (2002) and AdSense (2003). Today staff joke it's "120% time".	**CHALLENGE** Give people time and products follow: "20% time" produced Google News (2002) and AdSense (2003). But as a company grows, that time gets squeezed. Staff now joke it's "120% time".
♥	**5-day sprint, test with users** How they understand people	The Design Sprint (Jake Knapp, 2010): five days to map, sketch, decide, prototype and test with real customers.	**INSIGHT** Five days beats five months of debate. The Design Sprint (Jake Knapp, 2010) goes from problem to a prototype tested with real customers in one week.
♦	**#MonkeyFirst: hardest part first** How they test	At X, the moonshot lab, #MonkeyFirst: do the hardest part first, and stop the project if it can't be solved.	**INSIGHT** Do the hardest part first. At X, Google's moonshot lab, #MonkeyFirst means: if the hard part can't be solved, stop before you spend money on the easy parts.
♣	**OKRs + safe teams** How they scale	OKRs since 1999 (an objective + measurable key results). Project Aristotle (2015): psychological safety is the #1 trait of effective teams.	**INSIGHT** The best teams are safe teams. Project Aristotle (2015) found that being able to speak up without fear is the #1 trait of effective teams. OKRs (Objectives and Key Results) keep everyone aiming at the same goal.

✋ **STEAL THIS, THIS WEEK**

Run a one-day mini-sprint: map, sketch, vote, make a paper prototype, then test it with 5 people.

× **MYTH CHECK**

"Gmail came from 20% time." It was Buchheit's assigned project. Google News and AdSense are the real 20% examples.

Sources for this page: [20] Wikipedia: Side project time (20%) · [21] Quartz: "120% time" · [22] GV: The Design Sprint · [23] Inc: #MonkeyFirst at X · [24] Google re:Work: Project Aristotle (PDF)

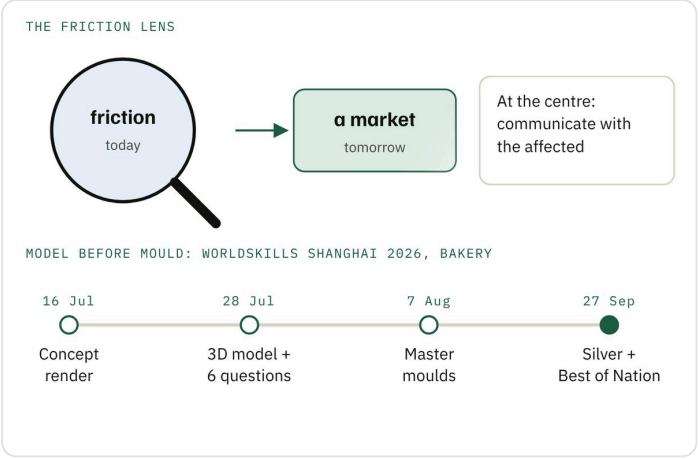
VNV Printlab

VNV PRINTLAB · CO-FOUNDED 2019 · DESIGN + MAKING

No R&D (research and development) budget, so: notice friction, talk to the people affected, and show them a model first.

TRUE STORY · 2026

WorldSkills Shanghai, Bakery. Lavonne's Smriti Nambiar needed an 85 cm bread showpiece: a winged horse on clouds, with a pagoda. VNV designed it in 3D and made the moulds. Result: Silver, and India's Best of Nation. [25, 26, 27]



The four suits HOW THEY PLAY EACH SUIT · WHAT WE LEARN FROM IT

	THE MOVE	HOW THEY DO IT	WHAT WE LEARN
♠	**Friction lens** Where ideas start	The friction lens: today's friction is tomorrow's market. Watch people (AEIOU), note what annoys them, look for the smallest change.	OPPORTUNITY Today's friction is tomorrow's market. Watch people using AEIOU (Activities, Environments, Interactions, Objects, Users), note what annoys them, and look for the smallest fix.
♥	**Communicate with the affected** How they understand people	The 6C process (2013) has one rule at its centre: communicate with the affected. Then the dignity test: does it respect what people value?	INSIGHT The people affected know what you don't. The 6C process (2013) puts "communicate with the affected" at its centre, then asks: does the idea respect what they value?
♦	**3D model → 6 questions → moulds** How they test	Model before mould. For WorldSkills 2026, VNV shared a 3D model with six questions for the chefs, got answers within the hour, then made silicone moulds sized to the competition oven.	INSIGHT Ask the experts the right questions early. For WorldSkills, VNV sent the chefs a 3D model and six questions (will textures show in dough? bake in parts? how tall?) and had answers within the hour, before a single mould was made.
♣	**AI brains carry the lessons** How they scale	AI "brains": every project's methods and lessons are saved, so the next one starts where the last one ended. 35 jobs logged in 6 weeks.	OPPORTUNITY A small studio can remember like a big company. Every VNV project's methods and lessons go into AI (artificial intelligence) "brains", so the next job starts where the last one ended.

✋ **STEAL THIS, THIS WEEK**

Show a sketch or model to 3 real customers before you build anything.

× **MYTH CHECK**

"You need a big R&D budget to innovate." You need a short loop with the people affected.

Sources for this page: [25] The CSR Journal: Smriti Nambiar wins Silver and Best of Nation · [26] NewKerala (ANI): "It feels great" · [27] GKToday: India ranks 10th at WorldSkills Shanghai 2026

Appendix C · Short forms

3M · Minnesota Mining and Manufacturing, the company's original name

5 E's · Entice, Enter, Engage, Exit, Extend: the stages of a customer journey

6C · Face a concern, Find a cause, Compare research, Conceive, Convince, Continue; Communicate with the affected at the centre

ABC · American Broadcasting Company (US TV network)

AEIOU · Activities/Activity, Environment, Interaction, Object, User

AI · Artificial Intelligence

C-Lab · Creative Lab, Samsung's in-house incubator (2012)

DRI · Directly Responsible Individual: one owner per task (Apple)

d.school · Hasso Plattner Institute of Design at Stanford University

HBR · Harvard Business Review

HTA · Hierarchical Task Analysis

IDEO · Not a short form: from the Greek for "idea"

KED · Korea Economic Daily

L.I.F.E · Love, Identity, Freedom, Expression

NPR · National Public Radio, USA

OKRs · Objectives and Key Results

QR code · Quick Response code

R&D · Research and Development

SADI · Samsung Art and Design Institute, Seoul (1995)

S·C·O·R·E · Scenario, Challenge, Opportunity, Resolution, Expansion

SFIMAR · St. Francis Institute of Management and Research

VIP Center · Value Innovation Program Center, Samsung (1998)

VNV · VNV Printlab: design and fabrication studio, Mumbai (2019)

WWDC · Worldwide Developers Conference (Apple)

X · Google's moonshot lab, once called Google X

#MonkeyFirst · X's motto: do the hardest part first

Appendix D · Sources NUMBERS MATCH THE [N] MARKS · ALL LINKS CHECKED 15–16 OCT 2026

[1] Stanford Magazine: Mighty Mouse
https://stanfordmag.org/contents/mighty-mouse

[2] IDEO U: 7 rules of brainstorming
https://ideou.com/blogs/inspiration/7-simple-rules-of-brainstorming

[3] IDEO: design thinking
https://designthinking.ideo.com/

[4] Wikipedia: IDEO
https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/IDEO

[5] HBR: How Apple Is Organized for Innovation (2020)
https://hbr.org/2020/11/how-apple-is-organized-for-innovation

[6] TechCrunch: "Focus is about saying no"
https://techcrunch.com/2011/10/06/jobs-focus-is-about-saying-no

[7] Macworld: The birth of the iPod
https://www.macworld.com/article/214911/the-birth-of-the-ipod.html

[8] MacTrast: design team testimony (2012)
https://www.mactrast.com/2012/08/apple-designers-maniacal-individuals-around-a-kitchen-table/amp/

[9] MRweb: Apple's buyer surveys
https://www.mrweb.com/drno/news15882.htm

[10] KED Global: Frankfurt Declaration
https://www.kedglobal.com/newsView/ked202310180015

[11] Samsung Design: history
https://design.samsung.com/kr/contents/design-history/phase-2.html

[12] Samsung Newsroom: 8-point battery check
https://news.samsung.com/global/samsung-announces-new-and-enhanced-quality-assurance-measures-to-improve-product-safety

[13] Samsung Newsroom: C-Lab
https://news.samsung.com/global/samsung-electronics-announces-support-for-five-new-startups-spun-off-from-its-c-lab-program

[14] NPR / WWNO: the 1995 phone fire
https://www.wwno.org/2013-04-01/how-did-samsung-win-with-smartphones-the-great-phone-incineration-of-1995

[15] 3M: 15% Culture
https://www.3m.com/3M/en_US/careers-us/culture/15-percent-culture

[16] Smithsonian: the invention of Scotch tape
https://www.smithsonianmag.com/innovation/how-invention-scotch-tape-led-revolution-how-companies-owned-employees-180972437/

[17] MNopedia: Post-it Notes
https://mnopedia.org/thing/post-it-notes

[18] Tuck case: 3M
https://mba.tuck.dartmouth.edu/pages/faculty/chris.trimble/osi/downloads/20002_3M.pdf

[19] 3M Q4 2025 earnings call
https://www.fool.com/earnings/call-transcripts/2026/01/20/3m-mmm-q4-2025-earnings-call-transcript/

[20] Wikipedia: Side project time (20%)
https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Side_project_time

[21] Quartz: "120% time"
https://qz.com/116196/google-engineers-insist-20-time-is-not-dead-its-just-turned-into-120-time

[22] GV: The Design Sprint
https://gv.com/sprint/

[23] Inc: #MonkeyFirst at X
https://www.inc.com/business-insider/alphabet-google-x-moonshot-labs-how-people-work-productivity-monkey-first.html

[24] Google re:Work: Project Aristotle (PDF)
https://www.michigan.gov/documents/mdhhs/Google-and-Psychological-Safety_684425_7.pdf

[25] The CSR Journal: Smriti Nambiar wins Silver and Best of Nation
https://thecsrjournal.in/baker-smriti-nambiar-wins-silver-best-of-nation-award-worldskills-shanghai-2026

[26] NewKerala (ANI): "It feels great"
https://www.newkerala.com/news/a/it-feels-great-baker-smriti-nambiar-wins-silver-809.htm

[27] GKToday: India ranks 10th at WorldSkills Shanghai 2026
https://www.gktoday.in/india-ranks-10th-at-worldskills-shanghai-2026/

[28] AEIOU: Rick E. Robinson, "Building a Useful Research Tool: An Origin Story of AEIOU", EPIC (2015)
https://www.epicpeople.org/building-a-useful-research-tool/

[29] 5 E's: IIT Institute of Design, "What is the 5E framework?"
https://id.iit.edu/resource-library/glossary/what-is-the-5e-framework/

[30] Task analysis: Usability Body of Knowledge, Hierarchical Task Analysis
https://usabilitybok.org/hierarchical-task-analysis

[31] Design-thinking modes: Stanford d.school
https://dschool.stanford.edu/

Disclaimer

For learning only. These notes support a classroom session. They summarise publicly available sources (listed with links in Appendix D) and the speaker's own methods and experience.

Checked, not guaranteed. Every company fact was checked against at least one source before the session. Sources can still be wrong, incomplete or out of date, and so can we. Check anything important for yourself before you rely on it.

Not professional advice. Nothing here is legal, financial, investment, medical or other professional advice.

Names and trademarks. Company names, products and trademarks belong to their owners and are used only to describe and teach. No company named here has reviewed, sponsored or endorsed these notes, the session or the phone app.

Limitation of liability. To the fullest extent the law allows, Nishit Kamath and The Next Hand accept no liability for any loss or damage arising from the use of, or reliance on, these notes, the session or The Next Hand · Live app, which are provided as is.

Corrections. Spotted an error? Tell us via LinkedIn (linkedin.com/in/nishitkamath) and we'll fix it.

Credits and rights

Nishit Kamath's own methods: the 6C design process (ArtCenter, 2013), the S·C·O·R·E Experiment Card, the four-suits lens and L.I.F.E ("Mobility Dignified", 2025). **Others' methods, credited where used:** AEIOU (Doblin Group), the 5 E's (Ben Jacobson, Conifer Research), hierarchical task analysis (Annett & Duncan), design-thinking modes (Stanford d.school), human-centred design and the 7 brainstorm rules (IDEO), the Design Sprint (Jake Knapp, Google Ventures). The InnoHatch cards are adapted from the Mobility VIP cards (Walker, Wardle, Ogden, Muyres; ArtCenter, 2007).

© 2026 Nishit Kamath · The Next Hand. All rights reserved. You may print and share these notes unchanged, with credit, for non-commercial learning. Graphics drawn by The Next Hand for this session.